

Chapter 1 - Marriage Contract

Ning Fuyi finally brought her sinful life to an end.

If one were to speak of the most notorious person across the six realms¹, she believed that if she claimed second place, even a tortoise spirit that had cultivated for ten thousand years in a cesspit wouldn't dare claim first.

As the premier demon lord of the six realms, legend had it that she delighted in consuming human flesh and especially loved sucking bone marrow. After killing each person, she would reveal blood-drenched fangs and delve deep into their bodies to feed, aiding her evil cultivation.

Legend said that she harbored hatred for her sect. After becoming a demon, she single-handedly destroyed the renowned Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate², even dragging her mother's corpse—the Sect Master of Condensing Heaven³—from its ice coffin and striking it with hundreds of heavenly thunderbolts.

Legend also said that she resented her mother's white moonlight⁴, the revered Divine Venerable Chu Qingqiu⁵ of the six realms. Using treacherous schemes, she imprisoned her in a demon cave, subjected her to countless humiliations, and even carved out the heart of the Divine Venerable's beloved disciple before her very eyes.

Legend further said that in the end, she was pierced through the heart by the sword of Chu Qingqiu, who could no longer endure her actions, finally bringing peace to the world.

Various legends were countless. With so many tales told, even Ning Fuyi herself came to believe three parts of them, and some legends did have some basis in fact.

For instance, she truly did hate Chu Qingqiu—hated her to the bone.

She hadn't hated Chu Qingqiu before. Back then, she was just a little girl who found the other person unfathomably deep, with a heart full of concern for all living beings in the world. Just standing nearby, that person's presence was so overwhelming that one couldn't speak.

It wasn't until her mother was dying, when she knelt crying in the Purple Cloud Pavilion for a day and night, her tears dried up yet unable to wait for Chu Qingqiu to open the door—only then did she begin to hate. Again and again, this hatred grew ever denser.

In the end, she simply went mad once, researching resurrection formations, slaughtering all the immortal cultivators who attacked the demon cave as sacrifices, and binding Chu Qingqiu to make her watch it all with her own eyes.

Didn't Chu Qingqiu love all living beings? Didn't she love that arrogant little disciple of hers? Wasn't she always high above like a deity?

She would grind Chu Qingqiu into the dust.

And she had succeeded. That day, lightning flashed and thunder roared. Countless white lights trailing sparks tore through the sky, illuminating the blood-soaked ground. Ning Fuyi stood at the center of the carnage, toying with a white bone-colored jade flute in her hands. Her black robes seemed soaked in ink, remaining perfectly still despite the howling winds.

That woman was bound to a filthy bronze pillar. Her usually spotless white robes were disheveled and soaked with blood. That face, which had once made all six realms gasp in wonder, was right before Ning Fuyi's eyes, showing suppressed humiliation and compassion.

"Ning Fuyi, you are not beyond redemption. Stop this," Chu Qingqiu's voice trembled, tears flowing from her eyes and mixing with the dirty mud.

Ning Fuyi was overjoyed.

"Weren't you always heartless? When I begged you like that before, you remained unmoved. Why are you crying now?" Ning Fuyi laughed heartily—she felt she hadn't been this carefree in hundreds of years.

"Is it because you feel guilty toward my mother? Because I killed your beloved disciple? Or because I bound you?" Ning Fuyi's voice was low and dangerous. She slowly bent down, letting her breath spray across the woman's face, her fingers gently caressing that smooth cheek, watching those eyes that were usually deep as an ancient well gradually take on a red tinge.

She had never known that watching Chu Qingqiu suffer humiliation could bring her such pleasure.

The joy was brief. Ning Fuyi had always understood this. Later, she activated the formation, and then she saw great white light, and somehow Chu Qingqiu had broken free from her bonds, coldly thrusting a sword toward her.

The piercing pain through her heart made her want to cry, but she suddenly felt much more at peace.

Death? It was nothing more than this—taking nothing with her, departing from this floating life.

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Some chaotic dreams passed before Ning Fuyi's eyes, or perhaps they were scrolls painted with the past unfolding. Ning Fuyi felt the air around her become solid, wrapping around her so tightly that she couldn't move even a finger.

At first, the paintings all showed her—her alone, sometimes standing at the summit of sun and moon playing the flute, sometimes lying in demon caves feeling the wind, or holding her evil-doing emei thorns⁶, summoning heavenly thunder to strike down immortals who sought her life, scattering them like flower petals.

Later, others appeared in the paintings.

There was a man in battle armor who screamed for her to flee quickly, then was crushed to powder in the next instant. There was a woman gentle as willow branches who smiled and called her "Yiyi"⁷, then was burned to ashes by great fire.

Even a little white dog that only knew how to wag its tail was pierced through by a heavy sword.

Finally, the shocking and heart-rending images froze and dissipated. Ning Fuyi looked ahead in a daze, scalding tears flowing into her mouth, salty and bitter.

Wait, tears?

Ning Fuyi suddenly seemed to awaken. She blinked hard to clear the moisture from her eyes, and her vision and touch gradually became clear.

First to enter her sight was a pool of milky white water. Her entire body was soaked in the pool, long hair swaying with the undercurrents.

She felt pain like needles all over her body, followed by bone-piercing cold surging into her limbs and bones. Ning Fuyi shivered violently, only then realizing she wasn't wearing a stitch of clothing. Fortunately, the pool water wasn't transparent and could provide some cover.

Looking down again, she saw two lotus-root arms encircling her waist, feeling ice-cold to the touch. Her back was pressed against soft skin, and through the wetness, she could even sense that person's heartbeat.

She was actually being held in someone's arms while soaking in the water!

Even though Ning Fuyi had been a demon king for a hundred years, waking up to such an intimate scene inevitably stirred some thoughts. Fortunately, she had always been strong-willed and could at least pretend to be composed.

So she exhaled forcefully and turned to push that person away. But when she turned and saw clearly who it was, her composure could no longer be maintained.

She couldn't help but curse, slapping that person's chest with one palm. The woman holding her loosened her grip and, following the force, slid down and came to rest at the pool's edge.

That person was, clearly and unmistakably, Chu Qingqiu.

The very Chu Qingqiu who had just pierced her heart and lungs with a sword.

She saw that Chu Qingqiu was dressed as rigidly and properly as always, except for her pale neck, not showing half an inch of skin anywhere else. However, her clothing was soaked with water, clinging entirely to her skin, outlining the graceful figure usually hidden from view.

Her complexion was terrifyingly pale, with only traces of blood at the corners of her lips.

The scene before her left Ning Fuyi stunned for quite a while. Shouldn't she be meeting the King of Hell? Why was Chu Qingqiu here? Could it be that although Chu Qingqiu had pierced her heart with immortal power, she had fortunately survived?

The bone-piercing water made her shiver again. Only then did she remember she wasn't wearing clothes, so she reached out to conjure some clothing.

However, after struggling for a long time, no clothes appeared—she only turned red in the face.

"Where is my demonic energy!" she shouted angrily. Her small white hands, wet with water, waved forcefully. Only then did she squeeze out wisps of immortal power from her fingertips, extremely weak. After concentrating for a long while, she barely managed to create a piece of cloth, just enough to cover her body.

Ning Fuyi hurriedly put on the clothing and stood up, stepping barefoot onto the shore. Only after leaving that bone-piercing cold water did her body reluctantly warm up.

Now she was truly panicked. Whether one cultivated immortality or demonhood, only power was fundamental. Now, for unknown reasons, her entire cultivation had dissipated—this was no different from death.

A surge of violence rose in Ning Fuyi's heart. She narrowed her eyes and looked toward Chu Qingqiu in the pool. Regardless of anything else, it was true that Chu Qingqiu had stabbed her with a sword. If she didn't eliminate her now, when Chu Qingqiu awakened, there would surely be great calamity.

After thinking this through, she decisively bent down and grasped the woman's collar, forcefully dragging her onto the shore. Unable to summon her emei thorns, she used both hands to clamp around her slippery neck, applying force to take her life.

But Chu Qingqiu remained motionless, though her face gained some color. Those heartless and ungrateful peach blossom eyes⁸ were tightly closed, but her mouth moved slightly.

Ning Fuyi stared at those full, blood-stained lips, becoming somewhat dazed for a moment.

"Stop!" A stern shout came from somewhere. Before Ning Fuyi could turn around to look, she was struck in the waist and abdomen by a force. She grunted dully and flew far away, heavily crashing into a pillar and rolling to the ground.

Before she could lift her head, a gleaming curved blade appeared at her throat, stopping her movement.

"You stubborn fool! Master kindly saved you, yet you repay kindness with enmity! Master is kindhearted, but I won't indulge a waste like you!" The newcomer's voice was agitated. As soon as the words fell, the curved blade came slashing toward her face.

Having lost her demonic energy, Ning Fuyi's body was still agile. She quickly bent down and hid behind the pillar. The curved blade struck the pillar with a clang, leaving a deep white mark.

The newcomer seemed determined to kill her, their movements showing no hesitation. The curved blade was drawn again, slashing down overhead. Ning Fuyi frowned slightly, calming her mind as she dodged around the pillar, meanwhile using what little immortal power she had to create a sharp small knife.

Taking advantage of the attacker's inattention, she rolled to the side, grabbing Chu Qingqiu's clothing in the process, and both fell into the water together.

"Master!" The attacker screamed sharply but had to stop abruptly, glaring at Ning Fuyi standing upright in the water as if wanting to cut her into a thousand pieces.

In the water, the woman's black hair was scattered, making her skin appear ghostly white. One hand casually encircled Chu Qingqiu's shoulder and back, while the small knife formed from immortal power gleamed in her other hand, pressed against the still-unconscious Chu Qingqiu's heart.

"If you move another inch, I'll make your precious master suffer an inch more." Ning Fuyi grinned with red lips, smiling sinisterly. Seeing that person so angry their eyes were about to split, she felt some amusement rising in her heart.

Although Ning Fuyi was beautiful, she just wasn't likeable. When not smiling, she was cold; when smiling, she was inexplicably sinister. Now, forcefully restraining Chu Qingqiu like this, she seemed even more like a demon, her gaze dark and terrifying.

Though she disliked Chu Qingqiu, she had to admit the other person truly possessed unparalleled elegance. Now, lying in her arms with eyes closed, there was something of a withering beauty about her. It was just that usually she was so high above that ordinary people didn't dare approach.

That cloud-mother button⁹ on her collar was fastened all the way to the very top. The more it was like this, the more it made one want to peek. Previously she hadn't dared; now was different.

Thinking this, Ning Fuyi slowly lowered her head, appearing to sniff the fragrance at Chu Qingqiu's neck. Her forehead hair lightly brushed across the other's skin, and Ning Fuyi seemed to see a trace of blush on Chu Qingqiu's cheek.

"That's the Divine Venerable—Ning Fuyi, you've gone mad!" That person was so angry they were stamping on the spot, nearly fainting.

"Gone mad?" Ning Fuyi sneered, only then restraining her demon lord temperament. She looked steadily at the attacker's appearance, but when she saw clearly, she suddenly froze for a moment, an electric current surging through her limbs and bones.

Qiu Yi?

That beloved disciple of Chu Qingqiu's, Qiu Yi?

Even though Ning Fuyi had seen great storms and waves, she couldn't recover for a long while. Back when Qiu Yi was at the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she had looked down on her. After she became a demon, the resentment grew even deeper. Initially, Ning Fuyi had spared her life out of reluctance to kill, but she persistently refused to give up. Finally, she even rallied all the immortal sects to fight her to the death. Fighting to the very end, Ning Fuyi finally stopped showing mercy.

She had personally finished her off.

But now, why would this dead person appear here alive, with appearance and voice completely unchanged?

"Ning Fuyi!" Qiu Yi's rebuke interrupted her thoughts. Ning Fuyi suddenly became serious, pressing the small knife closer to Chu Qingqiu's heart, raising an eyebrow toward Qiu Yi.

"What is this place?" she asked.

"What are you pretending not to know?" Qiu Yi gripped the curved blade tightly in her hand.

"Bone-Scattering Cold Pool—how could you not remember?"

Bone-Scattering Cold Pool... Ning Fuyi slowly nodded.

This place was originally territory of the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Though the cold pool was extremely icy, it had miraculous effects for immortal cultivators, specially designated by her mother, the Condensing Heaven Sect Master, for Chu Qingqiu's use.

After she had destroyed the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she had also blown up this cold pool completely. Yet now this place had not only reappeared, but even the stubborn stones in the corners were identical to her memories.

Before she could think through the reason, the body in her arms suddenly moved. Her hand involuntarily tightened, but she vaguely felt light breath brushing past her ear.

Looking down, she met a pair of peach blossom petal-like eyes. Chu Qingqiu had awakened at some point, but she didn't struggle, just stared at her motionlessly.

After staring for a long time, teardrops seemed to slide from Chu Qingqiu's reddened eyes.

For some reason, being looked at by those eyes made Ning Fuyi feel somewhat dazed. Her right hand shifted slightly, but was grasped by two ice-cold fingers around her pale wrist, like thousand-pound shackles—she instantly couldn't move.

"You and I have now formed a marriage contract¹⁰. If you attempt to kill me, you would be violating the heavenly laws." Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyes and spoke calmly.

Footnotes:

¹ **Six Realms (六界)** - In Chinese mythology and cultivation fiction, refers to the six domains of existence: Heaven, Asura, Human, Animal, Hungry Ghost, and Hell realms.

² **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - The name of the sect where the story takes place. "Mountain Gate" refers to the entrance or the sect itself.

³ **Condensing Heaven (凝天)** - Literally means "Condensing Heaven," the name of Ning Fuyi's mother's sect.

⁴ **White Moonlight (白月光)** - A Chinese internet term referring to someone's first love or an unattainable, pure love that remains in one's heart like moonlight—beautiful but distant.

⁵ **Divine Venerable (神尊)** - A high-ranking title in Chinese cultivation novels, indicating someone who has reached near-godlike status in their cultivation journey.

⁶ **Emei Thorns (峨眉刺)** - A type of weapon, thin pointed daggers traditionally associated with the Emei martial arts school.

⁷ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi, derived from the "yi" (衣) character in her name.

⁸ **Peach Blossom Eyes (桃花眼)** - A traditional Chinese description for particularly beautiful, alluring eyes that are slightly upturned at the corners.

⁹ **Cloud-mother Button (云母扣)** - Traditional Chinese clothing fasteners made from mica, typically used on formal or ceremonial robes.

¹⁰ **Marriage Contract (婚契)** - In cultivation worlds, this refers to a spiritual/magical binding between two people, often more serious than regular marriage as it involves spiritual essence and creates mystical connections between the parties.